

A LIVE CAPABILITY POSITION READ

Should I Stay or Should I Move?

Read what your current work is building before you decide.

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What this read will not do

Read this first. It is what you can hold me to.

This read will not tell you to stay or leave.

It helps you determine what your current environment is building in you, what remains portable, and what category of move your evidence supports testing.

What you score today is a position you occupy, and positions change.

You will leave with a provisional read of your current state and the category of move your evidence supports testing.

The specific move needs a read of context a group room does not have.

This read informs a career decision. It does not replace financial, legal, medical, immigration, contractual or family judgment. Recording: teaching segments only. Your scoring, discussion and writing time are never recorded.

WHERE THIS COMES FROM

The room you are not in.

I had spent eighteen years inside the rooms where capability was assessed. In March 2026, I became the person outside the room.

What gets weighed when the doors close

Four questions. None of them appear on your review form.

- | | | | |
|---|--|---|---|
| 1 | How hard would this person be to replace? | 2 | Who outside this person's manager can vouch for the work? |
| 3 | Is this capability current, or was it current? | 4 | Does this person's value travel, or does it only work here? |

These are questions institutional rooms often weigh. Density and Optionality help you read the formation and portability questions underneath them.

The room reads your position whether or not you have.

WHAT YOU NEED TO READ FIRST

The question underneath the question

A fair question, and a reading that sits upstream of it.

WHAT YOU CAME IN ASKING

“Should I stay in this role, or should I go?”

WHAT DECIDES THE ANSWER

“Is this position still forming me, and does what it built travel?”

The first question is yours to answer and nobody can answer it for you today. The second one can be read more rigorously in this room, and it sits upstream of the first.

It also outlasts whatever is in the headlines. This reads your position against the category of disruption rather than the current episode.

How the two-hour session works

Four moves. You will score yourself twice, in full, both times.

- | | | |
|---|-----------------------------|--|
| 1 | Initial read | All twelve statements, as you read them today. No evidence required yet. |
| 2 | Calibration | The evidence protocol, and the three ways capable people misread their own position. |
| 3 | Evidence-backed read | The same twelve again, with evidence in both directions. You keep the first number. |
| 4 | Decide | Re-total, place again, and write your Next-Move Decision. |

Your first number is not a test you can fail. It is the reading you would have carried into a decision this week. The word for what happens in between is calibration.

DEFINITION ONE

Density

Learning velocity. Whether this environment is still forming you.

Density is the extent to which the environment you are in is still forming deeper capability in you.

It is a property of the conditions you work under rather than a measure of your effort. A role can be exhausting and forming nothing.

Density is not workload, busyness, pressure or intensity.

A hard week is not evidence of formation.

Six statements. You will score them in a few minutes.

DEFINITION TWO

Optionality

Market portability. Whether what you built is yours to carry.

Optionality is the portability and legibility of what you have built, beyond the context that built it.

It has two halves that people collapse into one: whether the capability transfers, and whether anyone with power outside your manager has seen it.

Optionality is not having offers in hand.

It is whether you could rebuild elsewhere, and whether the right people can already see why.

Six statements. Twelve in total, and you score all of them.

What AI changes about this reading

Sixty seconds. An application of the two axes, not a new axis.

Where AI makes routine output easier to reproduce, your position depends more heavily on judgment, learning velocity, and capability that travels across unfamiliar problems.

AI does not create Compounding. It raises the cost of mistaking familiar output for growing capability.

That is a reason to read the two axes carefully. It is not a separate score.

Fuller treatment in the appendix and on workbook page 25.

INITIAL READ

Your initial read: statements 1 to 3

Density. Live, silent. 1 strongly disagree to 5 strongly agree.

- | | | |
|---|---|-----------|
| 1 | In the last ninety days I have been handed a problem I did not already know how to solve. | 1 2 3 4 5 |
| 2 | I work close enough to people who are better than me that I can watch how they think. | 1 2 3 4 5 |
| 3 | My work is reviewed by someone who can tell the difference between good and adequate, and who says so directly. | 1 2 3 4 5 |

Type a number in each box. No evidence line yet, that comes later, and it is deliberate. Workbook page 4.

Your initial read: statements 4 to 6

Density, continued. Same window, same instruction.

- | | | |
|---|--|-----------|
| 4 | The feedback I receive changes what I do next, not just how I feel. | 1 2 3 4 5 |
| 5 | I regularly operate at the edge of my competence rather than the comfortable center of it. | 1 2 3 4 5 |
| 6 | Looking back six months, the work I do now would have been genuinely hard for me then. | 1 2 3 4 5 |

Type a number in each box. No evidence line yet, that comes later, and it is deliberate. Workbook page 4.

INITIAL READ

Your initial Density reading

Add the six. Hold the number. Do not share it.

DENSITY, INITIAL

____ / 30

19 to 30 is high on this axis. 6 to 18 is low.
Any score between 17 and 21 is a boundary,
even a high one.

Write it where you can see it. You will produce a second number later, on a different standard, and the pair is the point of today.

Workbook page 4. In Adobe Acrobat Reader the total calculates itself once all six boxes hold a valid score.

Your initial read: statements 7 to 9

Optionality. Same scale, same window.

- | | | |
|---|---|-----------|
| 7 | The capability I am building would be valued by an employer in a different industry. | 1 2 3 4 5 |
| 8 | I can describe what I do in terms of outcomes, not just my company's internal language. | 1 2 3 4 5 |
| 9 | If my role disappeared tomorrow, the capability I built would still be mine to carry. | 1 2 3 4 5 |

Type a number in each box. No evidence line yet, that comes later, and it is deliberate. Workbook page 5.

Your initial read: statements IO to I2

Optionality, continued. Last block of the first pass.

- | | | |
|----|---|-----------|
| IO | People with the power to hire or advance me, inside or outside my company, can already see what I am good at. | 1 2 3 4 5 |
| II | What I am learning is a transferable capability rather than a company-specific procedure. | 1 2 3 4 5 |
| I2 | I could rebuild a strong position somewhere else within a year. | 1 2 3 4 5 |

Type a number in each box. No evidence line yet, that comes later, and it is deliberate. Workbook page 5.

INITIAL READ

Your initial Optionality reading

Add the six. You now hold two numbers and a position.

OPTIONALITY, INITIAL

----- / 30

Two numbers is all the matrix needs. Cross them and you have a state.

This is the reading you would have carried into a decision this week. Before we go further, we place it.

Workbook page 5.

The four states

Density crossed with Optionality. Your current state reveals a form of exposure your job title cannot.

DENSITY: HIGH AT TOP, LOW AT BOTTOM

DEPTH TRAP

Deep expertise fused to one context.

COMPOUNDING

Deep capability that travels.

STAGNANT

The work stopped asking more of you.

FRAGILE

Options on paper, not enough depth beneath.

OPTIONALITY: LOW AT LEFT to HIGH AT RIGHT

Read this before you place yourself

The most important sentence in the session.

This is not a performance rating, a potential rating, or a nine-box grid. It reads your conditions, not your worth to an employer.

Performance and formation differ

Strong reviews and flat formation are routine companions.

State is not identity

A current condition, not a personality type or a permanent address.

A low Optionality score is not a verdict

It may reflect context-bound capability, weak translation, limited exposure, or a combination.

Your first score is not wrong

It is uncalibrated. Those are different things.

FIRST PLACEMENT

First placement

Your initial read, placed. Privately, and provisionally.

DENSITY: HIGH AT TOP, LOW AT BOTTOM

DEPTH TRAP

COMPOUNDING

Mark your square. Then write one number beside it: how confident are you in that placement, 1 to 5?

STAGNANT

FRAGILE

THE BOUNDARY RULE

If either score sits between 17 and 21, you are on a boundary. Read both neighbouring states.

OPTIONALITY: LOW AT LEFT to HIGH AT RIGHT

Hold this lightly. You will place yourself again, on different numbers, in about forty minutes. Workbook page 6.

STAGED RELEASE · MINUTE 31

Open Part B now.

Keep Part A open — you will need your initial totals, state, and confidence.
Open Part B only after every first placement in the room is complete.

CALIBRATION

Now we correct the reading.

Three things stand between a self-score and a defensible one: an evidence standard, three characteristic misreadings, and the difference between being valued and being formed.

The evidence protocol

This is what your second reading has to survive.

Every corrected score requires an evidence line from the last ninety days. Every score, in both directions.

A 4 or 5

At least one clear positive instance from within the window.

A 3

The mixed or inconsistent pattern. A 3 is a reading, not an absence of one.

A 1 or 2

What repeatedly happened instead, a counterexample, or no qualifying instance in the window.

Cannot support it either way? Write your most defensible number and add one question mark: 3?, 4?, 2?. A 3 means mixed. A question mark means unsupported.

CALIBRATION

Scoring the intended life

Misreading one. How the score goes wrong, and how to correct it.

HOW IT GETS SCORED

“My rotation into the new function was approved last month. Statement 1 gets a 4.”

HOW IT SHOULD BE SCORED

“The rotation starts in March. Across the last ninety days I solved problems I already knew how to solve. Statement 1 scores a 2, and the evidence line says so: no qualifying instance in the window. It changes when the rotation does.”

An intention is not evidence. The ninety-day window exists to keep hope out of the number.

CALIBRATION

Confusing being valued with being formed

Misreading two. How the score goes wrong, and how to correct it.

HOW IT GETS SCORED

“Three VPs ask for my read before anything ships, and I was named to the steering committee. Statement 3 gets a 5.”

HOW IT SHOULD BE SCORED

“Being asked for my opinion is not the same as having my work reviewed by someone who can tell good from adequate. Nobody has called my work merely adequate in two years. Statement 3 scores a 2, and what repeatedly happened instead was agreement.”

Praise, dependence, seniority and internal reputation can all coexist with declining formation.

APPLICATION

Why promotion can stop forming a high performer

The same misreading, in the place it is hardest to see.

A promotion can increase responsibility, visibility and dependence while reducing formation.

A high performer can move into approvals, representation, meetings and familiar judgment. Performance expectations rise while the number of genuinely unfamiliar problems falls.

This describes a possible change in Density. It does not assign a Career State without also reading Optionality.

Score the work, not the title. Take-home prompt on workbook page 25.

CALIBRATION

Reading low Optionality as a verdict on ability

Misreading three. How the score goes wrong, and how to correct it.

HOW IT GETS SCORED

“Statement 10 is a 2. Nobody outside can see me because I am not senior enough to be worth seeing.”

HOW IT SHOULD BE SCORED

“Statement 10 is a 2 because I have not published, spoken, or worked across a company boundary in three years. That is a fact about exposure. It tells me what to build.”

A low Optionality score may reflect context-bound capability, weak translation, limited exposure, or a combination. It is not a verdict on your ability or worth.

CORRECTION MAP

The whole map

Five corrections. This is the argument for scoring again.

ENTERING BELIEF

"The work is demanding, so I must be growing."

"I would have options if I decided to look."

"This is what my role gives me."

"They rely on me here."

"A low score means I am not good enough."

EXITING BELIEF

"A demanding role can stop forming me and still feel full."

"Options depend on whether people outside can already see what I am good at."

"I scored the ninety days I actually lived."

"Being needed and being formed are separate conditions."

"A low Optionality score may be about translation or exposure, not ability."

Score all twelve again

Evidence in both directions. Do not change your first number.

THE PROTOCOL, IN SHORT

4 or 5 one clear positive instance

3

the mixed or inconsistent pattern

1 or 2 what happened instead, or no qualifying instance **?**

most defensible number, marked once: 3?, 4?, 2?

Density I · 2 · 3 · 4 · 5 · 6

Optionality 7 · 8 · 9 · 10 · 11 · 12

Workbook pages 12 to 15. Write the corrected number and the evidence line under it. Your first number stays where it is.

You will compare your first and corrected readings and examine what, if anything, moved.

SECOND PLACEMENT

Re-total and place again

New numbers. A fresh placement, not a review of the first one.

DENSITY, CORRECTED

----- / 30

OPTIONALITY, CORRECTED

----- / 30

Re-total both axes first. Then place, then record confidence and the date.

DENSITY: HIGH AT TOP, LOW AT BOTTOM

DEPTH TRAP

COMPOUNDING

STAGNANT

FRAGILE

OPTIONALITY: LOW AT LEFT to HIGH AT RIGHT

When the evidence remains uncertain

The neighbouring-score sensitivity check. An operational pilot convention, not a statistical confidence interval.

- I Total the axis using the numbers exactly as you wrote them.
- 2 Total it again with every marked item one point lower.
- 3 Total it again with every marked item one point higher.
- 4 If all three stay on the same side of 19, and none lands between 17 and 21, place and mark it provisional.
- 5 If they do not, do not pick one square. Read both neighbouring states.

Keep every neighbouring score inside the 1 to 5 scale. A 1? is never tested at 0 and a 5? is never tested at 6. Three or more marked items on one axis: that axis is incomplete and you do not place on it today.

WHAT MOVED

What moved

Both readings, side by side. Three anonymous counts.

Did at least one of your two axis totals change by two or more points?

Did your square change between the first and second placement?

Did your confidence go down, stay the same, or go up?

Nothing about your working life changed while you were scoring. Only the reading did. You calibrated the first reading against a fixed window, a symmetrical evidence standard and named misreadings rather than intuition alone.

A confidence number that fell can be useful when the original certainty rested on an untested assumption.

What just happened

And what it says about every self-assessment you have ever completed.

Self-assessment has a structural limitation: the same person supplies both the evidence and the judgment.

That does not make self-assessment useless. It means the reading needs a disciplined correction process.

What corrected your number today was not new information about your job. It was a strict window, an evidence requirement applied in both directions, and three named failure patterns. That is what calibration is.

WHAT IT COSTS

What your state is costing you.

Not advice. Cost. Four readings per state: the immediate cost, the hidden cost, the cost of waiting, and the false reassurance that keeps you there.

A concise reference is on workbook page 19. The fuller treatment is in Section 5 of your Field Kit.

What each state costs

All four, briefly. Your short reference is in the workbook.

DEPTH TRAP

IMMEDIATE COST

Value legible inside one building, close to illegible outside it.

FALSE REASSURANCE

"They could never replace me here."

STAGNANT

IMMEDIATE COST

The clock is running and nothing is accruing on either axis.

FALSE REASSURANCE

"I am well regarded here."

COMPOUNDING

IMMEDIATE COST

Maintaining both axes requires continued renewal. A strong current position can make early slippage easy to miss.

FALSE REASSURANCE

"I am doing well, so this square has nothing to tell me."

FRAGILE

IMMEDIATE COST

What travels today is no longer being renewed by the work you are doing now.

FALSE REASSURANCE

"I could leave tomorrow."

Your short reference is in the workbook. The fuller treatment is in your Field Kit.

Write your own cost

One square. Four readings. Your words, not mine. Workbook page 20.

The immediate cost

The hidden cost

The cost of waiting

The false reassurance that keeps me here

What one more quarter in this state takes from me, in one line. Standing still becomes a condition you can evaluate deliberately.

Seven categories of move

Direction, not a plan. Your evidence helps you choose which category to test. Workbook page 21.

Remain and deepen

The formation conditions are real and worth protecting.

Translate what is built

The capability exists. The language for it does not.

Widen exposure

The work is good and the wrong people have seen it.

Test portability

Find out what travels before you need it to.

Repair formation conditions

Change the work, not the employer, first.

Prepare for exit

Your evidence gives you reason to prepare in case the conditions do not repair.

Seek an external perspective

High stakes, incomplete evidence, or a boundary position.

No square prescribes a category. Your evidence and constraints still apply.

The Next-Move Decision

Ten lines on workbook page 22. These five carry the weight.

- 06 The category of move my evidence supports testing is...
- 07 The first action I will take, and by when, is...
- 08 The person I will say this to, and by when, is...
- 09 The evidence that would cause me to revise this decision is...
- 10 The date I will rescore is...

Lines 01 to 05 are in the workbook on page 22.

EIGHT MINUTES, SILENT

Working session

Nobody talks, including me. Step away from the screen if that helps. You get a two-minute warning.

Two or three of you, out loud

Lines 6, 7 and 8 only. No scores, no employer names, no third-party names.

The category of move my evidence supports testing is...

The first action I will take, and by when, is...

The person I will say this to, and by when, is...

You are reading a decision, not asking for approval of it.

I will say what I notice about the reasoning. I will not tell you whether to do it.

Hearing others can help you test whether yours is specific enough.

CLOSE

Where you go from here

Three things. Everything here is already yours.

Your Field Kit

Yours now, unlocked today. Section 5 works out what your state costs in your own numbers. Section 7 is your rescore.

INCLUDED · UNLOCKED TODAY

The thirty-day evidence process

One line a week, workbook page 23. You will get one short set of questions on day thirty.

WORKBOOK PAGE 23

The ninety-day rescore

Section 7 of your Field Kit, the Quarterly Loop. It runs the same evidence process you were taught today. Put the date in line 10 before you leave.

YOUR FIELD KIT · SECTION 7

Nothing here is withheld. Today's read is complete on its own.

BEFORE YOU GO

You have read your position.
The move is the next conversation.

Put a rescore date ninety days out before you close the workbook. When your reading changes, notice what changed. Share it only if you choose.

Position Exposure Signals

Questions to investigate, not predictions.

YOUR CURRENT ROLE

Is the mandate being absorbed, narrowed, duplicated or repeatedly redefined?

Does the position depend on one sponsor?

Is most of the value legible only inside one context?

Is the work becoming less formative while expectations remain high?

Is the organisation redesigning the work without a clear future role for the capability?

These signals do not predict a layoff. They identify questions that should be answered before you treat a position as secure.

A ROLE OR ORGANISATION YOU ARE CONSIDERING

Why is the role open?

What work has been added, removed or consolidated in the past year?

Who can distinguish excellent work from adequate work?

Where have people in this role moved next?

How is AI changing the actual work?

AI and Compounding

An application of the two axes. Not a technology session.

Where AI makes routine output easier to reproduce, your position depends more heavily on judgment, learning velocity, and capability that travels across unfamiliar problems.

AI does not create Compounding. It raises the cost of mistaking familiar output for growing capability.

Read it through the statements you already scored: statement 1 for unfamiliar problems, statement 5 for the edge of competence, statement 11 for what transfers.

Take-home prompt on workbook page 25: which part of your output is becoming easier to reproduce, and which part of your work is deepening judgment another context would value?

What translation actually means

An application of the second move category. Not part of the timed core.

Legibility is not bragging. It is evidence translated into language another context can understand.

The problem

What was actually hard, stated without your job title.

The outcome

What changed, in terms someone outside can weigh.

The capability

What the work formed in you that would travel.

You do not need louder confidence. You need claims that can survive evidence.

Take-home prompt on workbook page 25.